

Northwind Retail Group

Employee Handbook & HR Policies

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Owner:	People & Culture Team	Applies To:	All full-time and part-time employees

1. Purpose and Scope

This handbook establishes the human resources policies of Northwind Retail Group ("the Company") and applies to all employees, including full-time, part-time, temporary, and contract staff, across all Company locations. These policies are designed to promote a fair, safe, and productive workplace and to ensure consistent application of employment practices. Nothing in this handbook constitutes an employment contract or a guarantee of continued employment.

2. Equal Employment Opportunity

Northwind Retail Group is an equal opportunity employer and prohibits discrimination or harassment of any kind based on race, color, religion, sex, national origin, age, disability, genetic information, veteran status, sexual orientation, gender identity, or any other status protected under applicable law. This policy applies to all aspects of employment, including hiring, promotion, compensation, benefits, training, and termination.

3. Code of Conduct

All employees are expected to act with integrity, treat colleagues and customers with respect, and comply with Company policies and applicable laws. The following standards apply at all times while conducting Company business:

- Maintain honesty and transparency in all business dealings and reporting.
- Protect confidential Company, customer, and employee information.
- Avoid conflicts of interest; disclose any potential conflict to your manager or HR promptly.
- Do not accept gifts or gratuities from vendors that could influence business decisions.
- Use Company property, systems, and resources responsibly and for authorized purposes.
- Report suspected violations of this Code through your manager, HR, or the confidential ethics hotline.

3.1 Anti-Harassment and Workplace Conduct

Harassment, bullying, retaliation, and discriminatory conduct of any kind are strictly prohibited. Employees who experience or witness such conduct should report it immediately to HR. All reports are investigated promptly and confidentially, and retaliation against anyone reporting in good faith is a violation of this policy subject to disciplinary action, up to and including termination.

4. Attendance and Leave Policy

Regular attendance and punctuality are essential to Company operations. Employees are expected to notify their manager as early as possible, and no later than one hour after their scheduled start time, if they will be absent or late.

4.1 Paid Time Off (PTO)

Employment Tenure	Annual PTO Accrual	Max Carryover
0 - 1 year	12 days	5 days
1 - 3 years	16 days	8 days
3 - 7 years	20 days	10 days
7+ years	25 days	12 days

PTO requests should be submitted through the HR portal at least two weeks in advance for planned absences. Unused PTO beyond the maximum carryover is forfeited at calendar year-end unless otherwise required by state law.

4.2 Sick Leave

Employees accrue one hour of paid sick leave for every 30 hours worked, up to a maximum of 48 hours per calendar year. Sick leave may be used for the employee's own illness or medical appointment, or to care for an immediate family member. A doctor's note may be required for absences exceeding three consecutive days.

4.3 Parental and Family Leave

Eligible employees (minimum 12 months of service) may take up to 12 weeks of job-protected leave for the birth, adoption, or foster placement of a child, or to care for a family member with a serious health condition, consistent with the Family and Medical Leave Act (FMLA) and applicable state law. The Company provides 6 weeks of leave at full pay for the birth parent and 2 weeks of paid leave for a supporting parent, with the remainder available as unpaid, job-protected leave.

4.4 Holidays

The Company observes 10 paid holidays annually, including New Year's Day, Memorial Day, Independence Day, Labor Day, Thanksgiving Day and the day after, and Christmas Day. A full holiday schedule is published on the HR portal each January.

5. Compensation and Benefits

5.1 Pay Schedule and Overtime

Employees are paid bi-weekly via direct deposit. Non-exempt employees are paid overtime at 1.5x their regular hourly rate for hours worked beyond 40 in a workweek, in accordance with the Fair Labor Standards Act (FLSA) and applicable state law. Overtime must be pre-approved by a manager whenever possible.

5.2 Health and Wellness Benefits

Full-time employees (30+ hours/week) are eligible for benefits beginning on the first day of the month following 30 days of employment. Available benefits include:

- Medical, dental, and vision insurance with Company contribution of 80% of the employee premium.
- 401(k) retirement plan with a 4% Company match, fully vested after 2 years of service.
- Employee Assistance Program (EAP) offering free confidential counseling and referral services.
- Annual wellness stipend of \$300 for gym memberships, fitness classes, or wellness apps.
- Basic life and AD&D insurance provided at no cost, with optional supplemental coverage available.

5.3 Employee Discount

All employees receive a 20% discount on Company merchandise, and up to 30% during designated employee appreciation events. Discounts are for personal use only and may not be resold.

6. Remote and Hybrid Work Policy

Eligible roles may participate in the Company's hybrid work program, allowing up to 2 remote workdays per week subject to manager approval. Remote work arrangements require:

- A reliable internet connection and a dedicated, distraction-free workspace.
- Availability during core business hours (9:00 AM - 3:00 PM local time).
- Compliance with all data security policies, including use of Company VPN and approved devices.
- Manager approval, renewed quarterly, and revocable if performance or availability standards are not met.

7. Workplace Health and Safety

The Company is committed to providing a safe working environment in compliance with OSHA standards and applicable regulations. All employees must:

- Follow all posted safety procedures and use required personal protective equipment (PPE).
- Report workplace injuries, near-misses, or unsafe conditions to a supervisor immediately.
- Complete mandatory safety training within 30 days of hire and annually thereafter.
- Refrain from operating Company equipment or vehicles while impaired by drugs or alcohol.

Any work-related injury must be reported using the Incident Report Form within 24 hours. The Company provides workers' compensation coverage as required by law.

8. Information Security and Confidentiality

Employees with access to Company systems, customer data, or proprietary information must protect that data at all times.

- Use strong, unique passwords and enable multi-factor authentication on all Company accounts.
- Never share login credentials or access badges with another individual.
- Report suspected phishing attempts or security incidents to IT Security immediately.
- Confidential information (customer data, financial records, trade secrets) may not be disclosed outside the Company without written authorization, both during and after employment.

9. Disciplinary Action and Termination

The Company generally follows a progressive discipline process: verbal warning, written warning, final written warning, and termination. However, the Company reserves the right to skip steps or terminate employment immediately for serious violations, including theft, harassment, safety violations, or gross misconduct. Employment with the Company is at-will, meaning either the employee or the Company may end the employment relationship at any time, with or without cause or notice, except as otherwise required by law.

10. Grievance and Reporting Procedure

Employees who wish to raise a concern about a workplace policy, decision, or the conduct of a colleague or manager should follow this process:

- Step 1: Discuss the concern informally with your direct manager, where appropriate.
- Step 2: If unresolved, submit a written complaint to Human Resources within 30 days.
- Step 3: HR will investigate and respond within 10 business days.
- Step 4: Concerns may be escalated to the VP of People & Culture if not satisfactorily resolved.

Employees may also report concerns anonymously via the confidential ethics hotline at 1-800-555-0199 or ethics@northwindretail-example.com. Retaliation against anyone raising a good-faith concern is prohibited.

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